

It needs to evolve with the times like the IYC. Joshi too talks about wooing the young. But he offers nothing more than an outdated Congress ideology. Contrast this with the revamped Youth Congress that is on an membership overdrive with Rahul's face on its advertisements. How can Joshi compete? His answer is to propose fashionable white-peak caps and jackets that could be worn during relief operations to woo the young. As a Seva Dal worker quipped, "Even Gandhiji needed a Munna Bhai to hard sell him."

The Mahila Congress has a tougher task as it is seen by its male colleagues as a bargaining shop for women reservations in various committees. Some say it should be disbanded now that reservations have ensured that women are being 'represented' within the party. At present, there is only one woman of the nine general secretaries and five out of 40 secretaries. The Mahila Congress office is restricted to a few rooms tucked away in the corner of the headquarters where perfumed middle-aged women, dressed in crisp cottons, bristle angrily when referred to as a kitty club and bring forth a laundry list of agitations. "Sonijaji has

VIKRAM SHARMA



(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP) MAHILA CONGRESS PRESIDENT PRABHA THAKUR IN HER OFFICE; INDIAN YOUTH CONGRESS CHIEF ASHOK TANWAR; SEVA DAL CHIEF ORGANISER MAHENDRA JOSHI

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told me that the Mahila Congress should not be limited to political duties but also social work," says Prabha Thakur, the president. She took a delegation to the prime minister and Sonia to lobby for reservations for women in Central Government jobs. The rest of her itinerary too is a predictable list of women's issues to keep up the image of a 'sister-in-need'. Routine chores mostly, as it is yet to build a distinctive identity of its own. A far cry from what Indira Gandhi had envisaged when she wanted to counter the Durga Vahini of the Sangh. And when they do think 'out of the box', they bring out a brochure on Sonia. "That is not fair. The Mahila Congress works hard in campaigns.

We can go right up to the kitchens unlike the men," says Thakur. Yet their work is not appreciated by their colleagues barring a few exceptions such as Kapil Sibal, Ghulam Nabi Azad and V. Narainswamy. Both Joshi and Thakur can give direction but only a dynast can fire the organisation.

Each organisation needs to develop a niche role that becomes its USP. The IYC under Rahul is not the brash outfit it was under Sanjay. With Rahul wooing young professionals, it is a kinder, gentler set-up. Tanwar talks about the *Aam Admi ke Sipahi*, Youth Congress soldiers, at the Panchayat level to monitor development programmes. "You have to locate the role of any organisation in the

context of the times. The need today is for a more democratic and open system of functioning with a greater cerebral content," says Manish Tiwari, a former IYC chief.

Rahul has begun the process of change with the youth wings. However, the rest of the frontal organisations too need a makeover. A general secretary said somewhat harshly of the Seva Dal, "Let us just disband the dinosaurs of the past." The same could be true of the INTUC which functions more like a travel agent's office to global seminars than a trade union. As with all things in the Congress, change will have to be initiated from the top, otherwise these outfits are doomed to languish in irrelevance. ■